THE BATTLE OF CHESAPEAKE BAY

In the summer of 1781 the heads of the French and American land forces fighting the British in North America appealed for support from the French fleet in the West Indies. The fleet's admiral, the Comte de Grasse, set off with 28 ships of the line for Chesapeake Bay, where a British army under Cornwallis was besieged at Yorktown. Part of the British West Indies fleet, 14 ships of the line commanded by Sir Samuel Hood, was sent in search of de Grasse, but arrived at Chesapeake Bay ahead of him. Finding no French ships, Hood continued north to report to Admiral Thomas Graves in New York. Hood's ships had barely disappeared over the horizon when, on August 29, de Grasse arrived and anchored inside Cape Henry, blockading Cornwallis from supply or evacuation by sea.

Underestimating the size of de Grasse's fleet, Graves added five ships of his own to Hood's 14 and sailed for the Chesapeake. On the morning of September 5 a lookout spotted the French fleet at anchor, revealing to Graves that he was outgunned and outnumbered. Nonetheless the British cleared for action and, in the words of a French officer "came down on us with … an assurance that made us think they did not know our strength." The French showed equal spirit. De Grasse had 24 of his ships available for battle, although he was short of some officers and crew who were currently ashore. Slipping their anchors, they emerged from behind the cape barely 45 minutes after sighting their enemy.



British surrender
British troops led by General Cornwallis surrender at Yorktown on 21 October 1871, after the failure of the British fleet to secure Chesapeake Bay. French ships fill the bay.

De Grasse ordered his captains to form a "promiscuous" line; whoever had his ship ready first would lead the van, the rest following when they could. Competing for the honor of leading the fleet, five of the fieriest captains had their ships well ahead of the rest. But Graves let slip the opportunity to attack this isolated van. He sought a formal battle in line. In order to sail in the same direction as the French (which was essential for a prolonged exchange of broadsides) Graves had to wear his ships together, a maneuver that reversed the sailing order. Hood, previously commanding the van, now found himself in the rear, while the former rear, composed of the least seaworthy ships, became the van.

It was around 4:00 p.m. before Graves signaled for close action, though he also maintained a signal to hold the line ahead. The British and French columns met at an angle, which meant that the ships in the van were fiercely engaged, while the center and rear stayed well apart. The boldest French commanders with the best trained crews duelled with British ships, some of which were having trouble staying afloat. In an hour of close fighting, the British suffered the worst of the damage. The captain of *Shrewsbury*, the lead ship, lost a leg, and *Intrepid*, the next ship in line, had 65 holes shot in her hull, as well as her rigging cut and masts shattered.

With Graves and Hood bickering over the way the battle had been fought, the British fleet went back to New York, missing a chance to intercept French transport ships bringing siege guns to the Chesapeake. By the time Graves returned with a relief expedition in October, the blockaded General Cornwallis had surrendered, ensuring the independence of the United States. Tactically indecisive, Chesapeake Bay was strategically one of the most decisive sea battles in history.

AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR



BATTLE OF CHESAPEAKE BAY

Date	September 5, 1781
Location	Off Chesapeake Bay, Virginia
Result	French victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	FRANCE

COMMANDERS

Thomas Graves	Comte de Grasse

FORCES

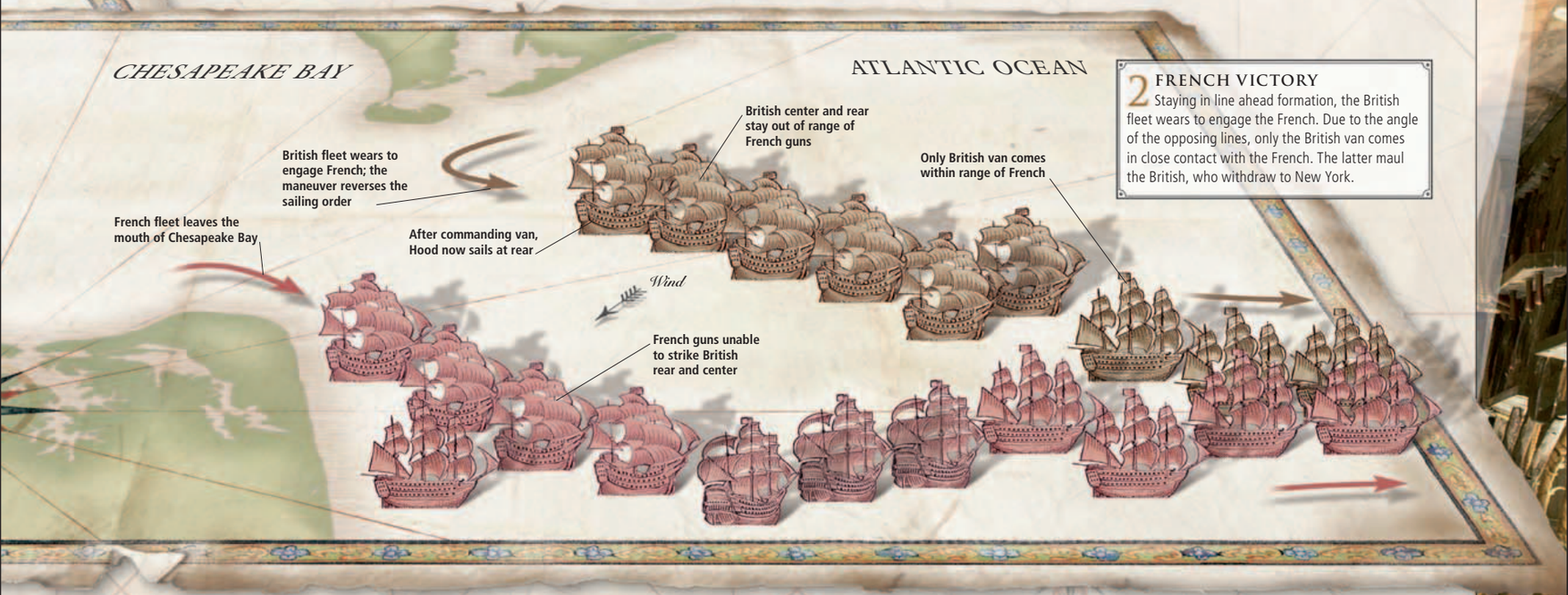
Ships: 19 ships of the line	**Ships:** 24 ships of the line

LOSSES

Men: 207 **Ships:** none	**Men:** 209 **Ships:** none



Boatswain's call
Whistles such as this are used for conveying orders aboard ship. The design has changed little from medieval times to the present day.



2 FRENCH VICTORY
Staying in line ahead formation, the British fleet wears to engage the French. Due to the angle of the opposing lines, only the British van comes in close contact with the French. The latter maul the British, who withdraw to New York.